



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



First Find

First Find 



Easy

General Skills

picoGym Exclusive

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Hints 

Description

(None)

Unzip this archive and find the file named 'uber-secret.txt'

- [Download zip file](#)

64,312 users solved



89%

Liked



picoCTF{FLAG}

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Challenge: First Find

Category: General Skills

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I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to locate a specific hidden file inside a large directory structure and extract the picoCTF flag contained within it. The challenge emphasizes the importance of **file discovery** rather than content searching.

II. Background

In Linux-based systems, challenges often involve navigating complex directory structures containing thousands of files. While tools such as `grep` are effective for searching text **inside files**, they are not always suitable for locating files by name. This challenge focuses on understanding the distinction between **searching for file names** and **searching file contents**, a critical concept in system administration, forensics, and cybersecurity.

III. Tool Used

- **Oracle VirtualBox (Kali Linux)** – Used as the Linux environment
- **Linux Terminal** – Used to execute decoding commands
- **unzip** – Extracts the contents of the compressed archive
- **find** – Searches for files based on name, type, and location

IV. Methodology

1. Opened Oracle VirtualBox and launched Kali Linux
2. Unzipped the provided archive using the `unzip` command



```
(kali@kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles]
$ unzip files.zip
Archive:  files.zip
  creating:  files/
  creating:  files/satisfactory_books/
  creating:  files/satisfactory_books/more_books/
  inflating: files/satisfactory_books/more_books/37121.txt.utf-8
  inflating: files/satisfactory_books/23765.txt.utf-8
  inflating: files/satisfactory_books/16021.txt.utf-8
  inflating: files/13771.txt.utf-8
```

3. Change my directory to the file from extracted zip

```
(kali@kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles]
$ cd files
```

4. Used the find command to search specifically for the file named uber-secret.txt

```
(kali@kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles/files]
$ find . -name "uber-secret.txt"
./adequate_books/more_books/.secret/deeper_secrets/deepest_secrets/uber-secret.txt
```

5. Opened the located file to retrieve the flag using “cat”

```
(kali@kali)-[/media/sf_Downloaded_Cybersecfiles/files]
$ cat ./adequate_books/more_books/.secret/deeper_secrets/deepest_secrets/uber-secret.txt
picoCTF{f1nd_15_f457_ab443fd1}
```

V. Result

picoCTF{f1nd_15_f457_ab443fd1}

```
picoCTF{f1nd_15_f457_ab443fd1}
```

VI. Explanation

“Why find is the correct tool for this challenge?”

The key difference in this challenge is that **the flag is not meant to be discovered by scanning file contents**. Instead, the challenge explicitly states:



“Unzip this archive and find the file named 'uber-secret.txt'”

This indicates that the task is about **locating a file by name**, not searching for text inside files.

The command used:

find . -name "uber-secret.txt"

Purpose:

- **find** searches the directory tree recursively
- **-name** matches file names, not contents
- **“ . ”** means start here
- **“uber-secret.txt”** means exact name

Efficient for discovering files regardless of their contents

“Why grep does NOT work here?”

Purpose of grep

grep searches **inside files** for matching text patterns.

Example:

grep -r picoCTF

This command:

- Looks through file contents
- Only works if the flag text is visible and readable
- Requires the correct file to already be accessed

Why grep fails in this challenge

- The flag is **not meant to be searched blindly**
- The challenge requires finding a **specific file**, not text
- grep does not search filenames
- Running grep without knowing the correct file results in no meaningful output

“Why strings also fails?”

Purpose of strings

The strings command extracts readable text from **binary files**.

Example:

strings file | grep picoCTF

“Why it is ineffective here?”

- The target file is a **normal text file**
- The problem is not file encoding or obfuscation
- The challenge is about **file discovery**, not hidden text extraction



Using strings adds unnecessary complexity and does not solve the root problem.

“What makes this challenge different from Big Zip?”

Big Zip

Flag hidden inside many files

Requires content searching

grep -r is effective

Text scanning challenge

First Find

Flag stored in one specific file

Requires filename searching

find is required

File discovery challenge

In **Big Zip**, the goal is to scan massive amounts of text efficiently.

In **First Find**, the goal is to **locate the correct file first**, then read it.

VII. Conclusion

This challenge demonstrates that selecting the correct tool is essential in cybersecurity tasks. While grep is powerful for searching file contents, it is ineffective when the problem requires identifying a file by name. The find command is the appropriate solution when navigating large directory structures to locate specific files.

Understanding the difference between **content searching** and **file discovery** is a fundamental skill in Linux, digital forensics, and capture-the-flag challenges.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**